

About the Authority Delegation Standard (ADS)

Canonical Definition

Authority Delegation Standard (ADS) defines the structural conditions under which authority may be delegated, transferred, assigned, distributed, inherited, accepted, exercised, governed, and reconstructed while preserving legitimacy, traceability, accountability, continuity, and operational validity throughout the delegation lifecycle.

ADS governs authority delegation.

The standard establishes the foundational conditions required to determine how authority moves between actors and whether delegated authority remains valid throughout operational environments.

What This Standard Is

ADS is a parent standard of the Accountability Governance Architecture (AGA™).

It governs:

- authority delegation
- authority transfer
- authority assignment
- authority distribution
- authority inheritance
- delegation continuity
- delegation accountability
- delegated authority governance

ADS establishes the governance layer responsible for preserving visibility of authority movement across operational systems.

What This Standard Is Not

ADS is not:

- an authority creation standard
- a responsibility standard
- a capability standard
- a control standard
- an oversight standard
- an evidence standard
- an accountability standard

ADS does not determine who originally possessed authority.

ADS determines how authority moves from one actor to another.

Why This Standard Exists

Most modern operational environments function through delegated authority.

Authority frequently originates at one level and is exercised at another.

Examples include:

- executive to manager
- manager to supervisor
- supervisor to worker
- organization to contractor
- contractor to subcontractor
- human to AI system
- orchestration system to AI agent
- AI agent to execution system

As authority moves through operational environments, governance visibility often decreases.

Delegation chains become longer.

Authority becomes harder to reconstruct.

Accountability becomes increasingly difficult to determine.

ADS exists because delegated authority has become a distinct governance space.

Core Insight

Authority rarely operates directly. Most authority operates through delegation.

Operational Architecture Space

ADS defines the operational architecture space for:

- authority delegation governance
 - authority transfer
 - authority assignment
 - authority distribution
 - authority inheritance
 - delegation continuity
 - delegation accountability
 - Human-AI delegation governance
 - agent delegation governance
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- distributed authority systems

This space exists because authority increasingly operates through delegated structures rather than direct execution.

ADS governs whether that delegation remains valid.

General Use Case 1 — Multi-Layer Organizational Environment

Scenario

A large organization operates through executives, directors, managers, supervisors, contractors, and external service providers.

Application

ADS governs how authority is delegated throughout the operational hierarchy.

Result

Governance gains visibility into authority movement and preserves reconstructability of delegation chains.

General Use Case 2 — Orchestrated Agent Environment

Scenario

An orchestration platform coordinates supervisory agents, execution agents, external tools, and robotic systems.

Application

ADS governs delegation of authority throughout the intelligent operational environment.

Result

Governance gains visibility into how authority moves between humans, systems, agents, and execution layers.

Architectural Position

Within AGA™, ADS serves as the third foundational governance layer.

The architecture progresses:

Relationship → Authority → Authority Delegation → Responsibility → Capability → Control → Oversight → Evidence → Accountability → Consequence

Closing Definition

Authority delegation is not the creation of authority. Authority delegation is the governed transfer of authority between actors while preserving legitimacy, traceability, accountability, continuity, and operational validity.

Authority may be delegated, but governance visibility of delegated authority must never be lost. If delegation cannot be reconstructed, accountability becomes unreliable.

Related Documents

→ [Authority Delegation Standard - \(ADS\)](#)

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Canonical Source

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